

ARMED AND DANGEROUS:
The Dhruv helicopter



South American Surprise

DELHI In a breakthrough for the virtually non-existent Indian defence export sector, Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL) in Bangalore has bagged an order for seven Dhruv Advanced Light Helicopters worth \$51 million (Rs 214 crore) for Ecuador's armed forces.

The first Dhruv military utility helicopter will be delivered in six months to the South American country on the Pacific coast.

An ebullient HAL Chairman Ashok Baweja termed the deal a beach-head into South America. "It gives us access to other regional markets like

Brazil and Bolivia (where HAL is currently pitching the Dhruv)," Baweja said. HAL already has domestic orders for supplying 250 Dhruvs to the three armed forces, Coast Guard and Home Ministry.

Last month the Dhruv became the first Indian aircraft to participate in

an international airshow. Four Dhruvs wowed crowds at the Berlin airshow.

HAL had been aggressively hawking the 5.5 tonne helicopter to various South American countries including Peru and Chile for the past four years. But in the face of furious opposition from European and US manufacturers, the prospects for the Dhruv, previously exported only to Nepal, did not look bright. This year, it lost a deal to supply the chopper to the Chilean armed forces when it was beaten to the post by Bell helicopters, a deal aviation analysts say had more to do with political arm-twisting by the US than competitive prices.

Now, renewed by the deal, HAL is planning to set up a spares depot in Ecuador to service the choppers since the country is almost a day's flying time from India.

by Sandeep Unnithan

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

With the Left digging in its heels, the UPA Government is worried that if it has a showdown in Parliament over the Indo-US nuclear deal, some of its own MPs may go against it to secure their Muslim votebank.

VOICES



"Prime Minister Manmohan Singh is sulking. He has been rendered dysfunctional and the ragtag UPA Government is non-existent."

Rajiv Pratap Rudy, BJP spokesperson

"For those trying to create a rift between Ram and Rahim, I am an astrologer. And L.K. Advani is never going to become the prime minister."

Lalu Prasad Yadav, railways minister

"The time has come to go for the lesser evil. Politics shouldn't be governed by past prejudices and personal egos. We'll see what is best to avoid crisis (over the nuke deal)."

Amar Singh, Samajwadi Party general secretary

"An educated woman would ensure that the entire family becomes educated. Education has the power to transform women's position in the society."

Pratibha Patil, President

"We are Indians first and Maharashtrians later. Those who have stayed in Maharashtra for several years are all Maharashtrians."

Manohar Joshi, Shiv Sena leader

